

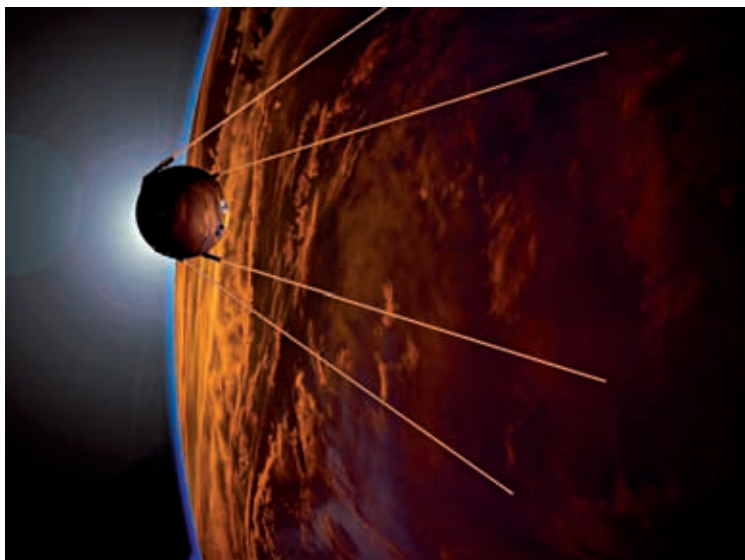


Image Credit: Gregory R. Todd

An artist's impression of Sputnik-1 in orbit

of the Russian R-7 intercontinental ballistic missile. After five minutes and 230 kilometres, the last of the R-7's engines shut down for good. Soon after, pneumatic locks were activated, a nosecone fairing separated, and an antenna spike was released. Then, in one final act that signalled the dawn of the space age, a pushrod connected to a bulkhead of the R-7 was activated, shoving a beach ball-sized sphere into the cold, harsh blackness of space. Sputnik had arrived.

Sputnik 1 became the first artificial satellite to be put into the Earth's orbit. A 22-inch aluminium sphere with four spring-loaded whip antennae trailing, it weighed only 83 kgs, measured a little less than two feet in diameter, and travelled an elliptical orbit that took it around the Earth every 96 minutes. It carried a small radio beacon that beeped at regular intervals and could, by means of telemetry, verify exact locations on the earth's surface. Some US cold warriors suggested that this was a way for the Soviets to obtain targeting information for their ballistic missiles, but that doesn't seem to have actually been the case. The satellite itself fell from orbit three months after launch on January 4, 1958.

It wouldn't be until two months after Sputnik 1 crashed back on earth that the US would be able to launch its own Explorer 1 satellite into space on March 17, 1958.